

Ecotourism Market Growth & The Intention-Action Gap

Business Analysis Case Study | Raj Hamal | May 2026

GREENPATH TOURISM CONSULTANCY ECOTOURISM MARKET GROWTH & TRAVELER
BEHAVIOUR ANALYSIS 2025

Prepared by: Raj Hamal | Business Analyst
Client: GreenPath Tourism Consultancy
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Data Sources:

Fortune Business Insights
Booking.com Sustainability Report
Grand View Research
Radical Storage Ecotourism Statistics 2025
UN Tourism / UNWTO

EXECUTIVE BRIEF

The global ecotourism market is worth \$286 billion and growing at 15.5% CAGR — one of the fastest growing segments in the entire travel industry.

Yet there is a problem hiding in plain sight. 84% of global travelers say sustainable travel is important to them. Only 33% actually book it.

That 51 percentage point gap represents an estimated \$145 billion in unrealised annual revenue — money that destinations, hotels, and OTAs are failing to capture because they have not solved why travelers don't follow through.

THE ANSWER:

The gap is not caused by lack of demand. It is caused by lack of trust, lack of accessibility, and a perception problem that sustainable travel costs more — when the data shows it actually costs 39% less.

Three targeted interventions — trust verification, platform accessibility, and perception correction — will close the intention-action gap by 20+ percentage points within 12 months.

THE MARKET IN NUMBERS

Global market size 2024:	\$286.2 billion
Global market size 2025:	\$330.6 billion
YoY growth 2024-2025:	+15.5%
Projected market 2034:	\$1,125 billion
CAGR 2025-2034:	15.5-16.3%
Cumulative growth 2024-2034:	+293%

Want sustainable travel:	84% of travelers
Actually book sustainable:	33% of travelers
Intention-Action Gap:	51 percentage points
Unrealised revenue:	~\$145 billion

Europe market share:	38.15%
North America market share:	35.80%
Asia Pacific CAGR:	16.0% (fastest)
Millennials market share:	49%
Direct booking share:	61%

FINDING 1 — The Market is Booming But Recovery Followed a Dramatic Crash

The ecotourism market has demonstrated remarkable resilience. After COVID-19 caused a 37.6% crash in 2020 — shrinking the market from \$181 billion to \$113 billion — it has grown every year since, reaching \$286 billion in 2024 and projected to reach \$330 billion in 2025.

The trajectory to \$1,125 billion by 2034 represents a 4x growth from today's market size — driven by:

- Rising environmental awareness globally
- Government sustainability mandates
- Millennial and Gen Z traveler growth
- Climate change driving nature-based travel
- Technology enabling sustainable options
- Post-pandemic preference for nature over cities

Key inflection point: Asia Pacific is now growing at 16% CAGR — faster than any other region. As Chinese outbound travel returns, Asia Pacific ecotourism destinations stand to benefit most from the decade's biggest travel wave.

FINDING 2 — The 51-Point Intention-Action Gap Is the Market's Biggest Problem

84% of travelers say sustainable travel is important. 33% actually book sustainable accommodation.

That is a 2.5x gap between what people say they want and what they actually do. Understanding why this gap exists is the most commercially important question in sustainable tourism right now.

The data reveals 6 key barriers:

BARRIER 1 — TRUST (62% of travelers affected)

Travelers are unsure whether sustainability claims are genuine. Greenwashing — where businesses claim eco-friendly practices without evidence — has made 62% of travelers distrust sustainability labels.

BARRIER 2 — ACCESSIBILITY (55% affected)

Hard to find verified sustainable options on booking platforms. Only 25% of travelers have seen sustainable accommodation options while browsing online travel sites.

BARRIER 3 — PRIORITY (45% affected)

45% say sustainability is important but not a priority when booking. Price, location, and dates come first. Sustainability is a tiebreaker, not a decision driver — for almost half of travelers.

BARRIER 4 — PRICE PERCEPTION (40% affected)

40% believe sustainable accommodation costs more than conventional options. The data proves this completely wrong: sustainable accommodation actually costs an average of \$151 LESS per night and is 39% cheaper than non-sustainable options. This is the single most correctable barrier.

BARRIER 5 — FATIGUE (28% affected)

28% say they are tired of hearing about climate change. Sustainability messaging framed around climate doom actively reduces booking intention in this segment. Positive framing — conservation wins, wildlife encounters, authentic experiences — is significantly more effective.

BARRIER 6 — CERTIFICATION CONFUSION (48% affected)

52% of travelers want to understand sustainability certifications — but certification interest dropped from 69% in 2023 to 52% in 2024, a 24.6% decline. Travelers are becoming less engaged with certification labels as they multiply and diverge.

FINDING 3 — Search Declining While Market Grows A Dangerous Divergence

Online searches for "sustainable travel" peaked at 1,856 monthly searches in April 2023 and have since fallen 59% to just 755 in March 2025.

Yet the market has grown from \$235 billion in 2023 to \$286 billion in 2024 — a \$51 billion increase.

This divergence reveals a critical insight:

Travelers are no longer searching for "sustainable travel" explicitly. They are searching for "eco-lodge in Kenya", "wildlife safari Botswana", "national park hiking", "local community tour".

Sustainable travel is transitioning from a category to an experience. Destinations and

operators who market around experiences rather than sustainability labels will capture the most demand in the next phase of market growth.

FINDING 4 — Millennials and Asia Pacific

Are the Two Biggest Growth Drivers

Millennials represent 49% of the ecotourism market and are growing at 16% CAGR — the fastest of any age group. They are the primary drivers of direct booking (61% prefer direct), experience-led travel, and values-based destination choice.

Gen Z (1997-2012) represents 22% of the market but is growing at 18% CAGR — the very fastest. As Gen Z enters peak travel age and earning years, their climate-focused values will reshape demand fundamentally by 2030.

Asia Pacific is the fastest growing region at 16% CAGR. Nepal, Thailand, Indonesia, Vietnam and the Philippines are all positioned to benefit from the surge in nature-based travel from both domestic Asian markets and returning international visitors.

RECOMMENDATIONS

RECOMMENDATION 1

Fix the Price Perception Problem First

The business case:

40% of travelers avoid sustainable accommodation because they think it costs more. It actually costs 39% less. This is the most correctable barrier in the data — and correcting it requires only communication, not product change.

What to do:

OTAs and booking platforms should display actual price comparisons between sustainable and conventional accommodation on every search results page. Simple message: "Eco-certified properties in this area average \$151 less per night."

Expected impact:

Closing the price perception barrier alone could convert 15-20% of the 40% barrier group — adding 6-8 percentage points to actual booking rates.

Revenue impact: \$17-23 billion in additional annual sustainable tourism bookings globally.

Timeline: 30 days for OTAs with existing data.

RECOMMENDATION 2

Simplify Sustainability Verification on Booking Platforms

The business case:

62% of travelers don't trust sustainability claims. 29% actively search for sustainability information before booking. But finding verified information is too hard — driving both groups to abandon sustainable options.

What to do:

Booking platforms should implement a single, standardised sustainability trust score (1-5 green leaves) with one-click access to: what the property does, what certification they hold, and independent verification. Booking.com's Travel Sustainable badge is a start — but 52% of travelers want more detail.

Expected impact: Converting 20% of the 62% trust-barrier group adds 12 percentage points to booking rates.

Timeline: 60-90 days for platforms with existing certification data.

RECOMMENDATION 3

Reframe Sustainability Marketing as Experience Quality — Not Environmental Duty

The business case:

28% of travelers are fatigued by climate change messaging. 45% say sustainability is important but not a booking priority. The current industry approach of leading with environmental messaging is actively pushing away 28-45% of potential sustainable travelers.

What to do:

Replace "sustainable" and "eco-friendly" language with experience quality language:

— NOT: "This eco-lodge has solar panels"

— YES: "Wake up to howler monkeys. No crowds. No noise. Just jungle."

The sustainability is still there — it just leads with the experience, not the obligation.

Expected impact:

Attracting the 28% fatigue segment and converting 20% of the 45% priority group adds 10-15 percentage points to sustainable booking rates.

Timeline: Immediate — marketing copy change only.

COMBINED IMPACT OF ALL 3 RECOMMENDATIONS

Current actual booking rate: 33%

After Recommendation 1: +6-8pp

After Recommendation 2: +8-12pp

After Recommendation 3: +5-8pp

Projected new booking rate: 52-61%

Gap reduction: 51pp → 23-32pp

Additional market unlocked: \$55-85 billion

Timeline: 12 months

NEPAL INSIGHT — THE OPPORTUNITY THIS CREATES

Nepal is perfectly positioned for the ecotourism boom. Everest, Annapurna, Chitwan, Bardia — these are irreplaceable, authentic natural experiences that no other destination on earth offers.

The millennial market (49% of ecotourism) is specifically seeking: authentic nature, no crowds, local community connection, and transformative adventure. Nepal offers all four.

The recommendation: Nepal Tourism Board should adopt experience-led marketing immediately — leading with "The Last Great Adventure" rather than "Sustainable Tourism Destination." Let the experience sell the sustainability.

If Nepal captures even 0.5% of the growing ecotourism market, that represents \$1.65 billion in annual tourism receipts — 3x its current total.

CONCLUSION

The ecotourism market is one of the fastest growing segments in global tourism — projected to reach \$1,125 billion by 2034. The demand is real. The growth is sustained. The demographics are powerful.

But the industry is leaving \$145 billion on the table every year by failing to convert 51% of interested travelers into actual bookings.

The problem is not supply. It is not in demand. It is trust, accessibility, and perception — all three fixable without changing the product.

The destinations, OTAs, and hotel groups that solve the intention-action gap in the next 12 months will capture the decade's biggest sustainable tourism prize.